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Before Independence: Anarchy and Power

Understanding the Past

India's international relations before it gained independence in 1947 are often overlooked today. [1] But that history still matters, for it continues to shape India's identity and outlook in meaningful ways. The legacy of India's pre-independent history still influences the nature of the country's economy, the composition of its military, its networks of trade, the spread of its diaspora, its boundaries and unresolved conflicts, its religions, and its peoples' daily lifestyles.

The long view of India's international engagement also dispels some widely held misconceptions. One, easily refutable, is of India as a relatively novel political entity. In fact, an understanding of India by outsiders has been documented for well over 2500 years. Terms such as India, Shendu, and al-Hind (all of which derive from the same root, the river Indus or Sindhu) were long used by Europeans, Chinese, and Arabs respectively to refer to the region east of the Indus and between the Himalayas and the Indian Ocean. Indians, of course, referred to their own country by several different names: Jambudvipa, Bharat, and Hindustan. Although the exact geographical definition of India evolved, it constituted a region that had certain shared attributes, including the imprint of a common cultural and linguistic heritage. While the 'core' areas of India were never in doubt, a broad cultural definition potentially extended 'India' to a wider region, including at times parts of Central Asia and Southeast Asia. The idea of a Greater India has periodically captured the imagination, most notably in the context of India's independence movement during the early twentieth